

HUMBLE SUBMISSION Punjab CM Bhagwant Singh Mann at the Golden Temple complex in Amritsar, Jan. 15

been a scramble to fill the vacuum. The radicals, rival Akalis, AAP, the Congress, even the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), have made overt and subtle plays for it. But it's risky play, as AAP is discovering.

Panthic issues are a lightning rod for the rural Jat Sikhs who once constituted the core Akali vote bank. Governance failures formed the subsoil of their all-round disaffection with Sukhbir, but it was articulated as panthic anger on the 2015 sacrilege and subsequent police firing at Behbal Kalan: a strong legitimising pretext for a shift towards 'secular' options.

Absent resolution on those issues, and the disaffection has been getting transferred to AAP, with its own promise of governance miracles running into a reality check. Meanwhile, the panthic space came to be increasingly captured by the radicals, with even Khalistan sloganeering again turning kosher. The incarceration of Khadoor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh has capped that arc of volatility—sheathing the tip of the spear, gradually deflating the groundswell. The second line of hopefuls, a rival Akali 'Reform' faction led by former Akal Takht jathedar Giani Harpreet Singh, too, is losing steam. A key protagonist—Charanjit Brar, once a Sukhbir aide—joined the BJP recently.

BADAL MAY RAIN AGAIN

But the space is swinging back to the parent SAD. For years dismissed as a spent force, it finds a chance to invoke its historic role as the defender of Sikh pride. Concrete proof of what this reversion means came in the recent local body polls: the SAD gained in the Malwa region, seizing control of the Bathinda and Muktsar zila parishads, besides several panchayat samitis. A modest local revival, yet reinforcing the party's hold over traditional strongholds and hinting at a potential springboard for 2027.

Seeing these green shoots, Sukhbir is planning a campaign of rallies across all 117 assembly constituencies, a show of visibility as well as a statement of intent. The plan, finalised in a meeting of district presidents and booth in-charges, is to reconnect with the base that once powered Akali dominance.

The SAD also received a timely boost following the release of senior leader Bikramjit Majithia on bail on February 3. Majithia wasted no time in returning to the political battlefield, launching direct attacks on Mann, projecting himself as a victim of political vendetta.

Why did Mann's Banga overture backfire? Factual infirmities (the copies were not part of the missing *saroops*), police entry into the gurudwara, and the language he used ("unauthorised" copies). Inept repair work by finance minister Harpal Cheema didn't help. On January 21, he visited the shrine to calm the waters, said "no discrepancy was found" (contradicting Mann), then backtracking. With the Atishi episode still burning like crop residue, smoke fills the screen for AAP. Sukhbir, by now wiser from experience, is well placed to harvest the upcoming rabi crop. ■

Takeaways

- **AAP's series of blunders on panthic issues angers the Sikh street one year before polls**
- **With radicals and rival Akali factions in the shade, Sukhbir sees a chance of revival for the SAD**

▶ GUJARAT

PATIDAR POWER DAUGHTER

Anar Patel's rise to the helm of Leuva Patel trust signals a new axis of power in Gujarat, even if outside politics

By **Jumana Shah**

TO THE UNINITIATED, BEING PRESIDENT of the Khodaldham Trust may sound like having a lead part in provincial philanthropy—distinguished, but staid. But Gujarat's political landscape was set abuzz when Anar Patel, 55-year-old daughter of former chief minister Anandiben Patel, got that role recently. It was seen as announcing her entry, albeit a lateral one, into the upper echelons of Gujarat's power pyramid.

Named after the deity Khodal Mata, revered by the Leuva Patidars, the socio-religious body is immensely influential and virtually stands as an incorporated proxy for a community that numbers over 5 million. Headed by entrepreneur Naresh Patel, who will continue as chairman, it has an organisational footprint in 31 of Gujarat's 34 districts, and has deployed vast capital in religious and social infrastructure.

At its helm since 2017, Naresh has been wooed by the BJP, Congress and, of late, the Aam Aadmi Party. Ahead of every election, rumours fly of him being fielded by either the BJP, Congress or both, but he has never actually joined either or contested. "Nareshbhai's primary goal is community welfare. He